



Sweet revenge: Argentina claimed its third Women's World Cup title, and its first since 2010, exacting revenge on the Dutch after losing to them in the final four years ago.^{AFP}

the decisive penalty in the final, silence befell the Wagener. The Argentinians had their own Maracanazo moment, bringing an end to Netherlands' 12-year hold on the World Cup trophy.

It was the perfect revenge for Las Leonas, who had come second best to Netherlands across multiple World Cups and Olympic Games. Argentina's triumph was a significant moment in the sport, breaking the Dutch's monopoly as it previously did with its 2002 and 2010 World Cup wins. In fact, in the 21st century, Argentina remains the only team to beat Netherlands in the World Cup

across seven editions.

Fernando Ferrara, who took over after the Tokyo Olympics, had put together another group of players who could challenge the world's best. "Tactical, technical and physical things are important, but the head, to make it believe it's possible is the first condition," said Ferrara.

After a stuttering start, which included a 1-1 draw against the USA and a comeback 3-2 win over Germany, Argentina showcased defensive solidity by securing four successive cleansheets on its way to making the final.

It wasn't a smooth run to the decider, as it needed inventiveness to break open teams from Penalty Corners, particularly in the semifinal and final against Australia and Netherlands, respectively.

In the final, despite trailing in the second half, Argentina exerted

control while piling the pressure on the Dutch circle. But with dragflick expert Agustina Gorzelany struggling to make a mark from short corners, Argentina needed to come up with another variation. It did so through skipper Maria Granatto, who scored with less than six minutes left to find the equaliser.

For Granatto, who had endured several heartbreaks against the Dutch in the past, the time to step up and deliver was evident in her pre-match speech, when she said: "It's today! There is no tomorrow. It's today, damn it! More than ever, it's today!"

Less than two hours later, Granatto and her band of fearless women willed their way into history.

For both Germany and Argentina, it was a story of triumph through belief, even as history didn't seem to favour them.